

clocking constant currency revenue growth of 6.7% and maintaining enviable profitability with EBIT-DAAI (earnings before taxes, depreciation, amortisation and lease expenses) margins just shy of 37%. At present, Africa accounts for 24% of revenues, India mobile for 55%, India non-mobile for 13%, and Indus for 8%.

G. Chokkalingam, Director of Equinomics Research, points to market saturation as well as management's ability as key drivers behind Bharti Group's growth.

"At one point, the industry had over 15 private players. Today, there are only three, plus BSNL. The ability of Bharti's management to navigate consolidation, expand into 17 countries, and maintain healthy Ebitda margins of nearly 50%, even in Africa, has been equally critical," he says.

TECH FOCUSED

58 | Looking ahead, the company is transforming into a tech-driven conglomerate with four clear focus areas: building a diverse and resilient portfolio, acquiring quality customers, expanding its B2B networks, and strengthening digital capabilities.

In broadband, Airtel is sharpening its push to deepen its network reach and accelerate the rollout of fiber home passes, or the total number of homes and premises that are located within a fiber-to-the-home (FTTH) network's optical distribution network. "I want to get to a quarterly run rate of 2.5 million home passes, up from 1.6 million," said Vittal.

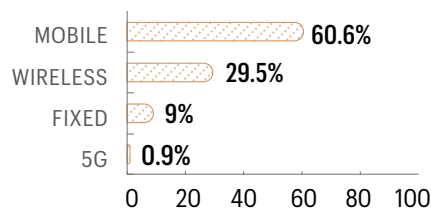
The B2B business is also seeing aggressive investments as Airtel works to build what it calls a gold-standard, faultless and reliable fiber network. "Our infrastructure, comprising low-latency fibre, submarine cables, OPGW fiber, and advanced data centres, is the backbone of our superior service quality and assurance," Vittal noted.

Beyond connectivity, Airtel is betting on cybersecurity, IoT, and Cloud, segments that are attracting new investments and already showing traction. The digital business overall is expanding rapidly, growing at 23%.

Artificial intelligence is going to be put at the heart of the group's businesses. "For the last 18 months we have been running experiments on AI, and one of

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- The mobile segment remained the growth engine, adding 1.2 million customers, including 3.9 million smartphone users
- The postpaid segment saw 0.7 million net additions, accounting for 57% of the total



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the things we have decided is to put it at the very heart of our businesses," Vittal tells BT. Recently, Airtel partnered with Perplexity AI to offer a complimentary 12-month subscription of its professional version to its customers.

CHALLENGES AHEAD

Even as the group continues its aggressive focus towards becoming a technology focused conglomerate, the transformation will involve formidable challenges. Chokkalingam says the biggest would be either maintaining or regaining its market share.

Analysts at Mirae Asset Sharekhan point to distress in pressure on realisations owing to increasing competition. "Continued decline in data volume growth could affect revenue growth. Any slowdown in Africa operations could affect revenue growth," says the research firm.

Religare's Singh, however, says growth is expected from digital services, enterprise solutions, and continued expansion in rural and international markets. **BT**

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